

Coelophysis

One of the earliest theropods, *Coelophysis* was a small and nimble, birdlike carnivore that darted after prey in the riverside forests of the Triassic Period, snapping up small lizards. It was built for speed, with lightweight, hollow bones and a slender frame. In 1998 a *Coelophysis* skull was taken on board space shuttle *Endeavour*, making it the second dinosaur (after *Maiasaura*) to visit space.

Coelophysis

SEE-low-FYE-sis



- **When** 215 million years ago (Late Triassic)
- **Fossil location** N. America, southern Africa, China
- **Habitat** Desert plains
- **Length** 10 ft (3 m)
- **Diet** Lizards and fish

Coelophysis was as long as a small car but as light as an 8-year-old child. With a long, curved neck and slender legs, it resembled a long-legged bird. In 1947 scientists made an amazing discovery of 500 *Coelophysis* skeletons piled together at Ghost Ranch in New Mexico—a *Coelophysis* “graveyard.” They seem to have died together, perhaps victims of a sudden flood. The find inspired stories of *Coelophysis* hunting in huge packs to overpower large prey, but there is no evidence this happened.

Coelophysis had hundreds of small, sharp teeth. They had sawtooth edges—a sign that it ate flesh.

Coelophysis had a long, flexible neck that formed an S-shape when relaxed, like the neck of a heron. By straightening its neck quickly, it could dart for fast-moving prey on the ground.

